AN ASSASSINATION

Abu’l Fazl marched through the hilly and broken countryside of central Hindustan with a small detachment of soldiers. After a lifetime spent at court in the intense pursuit of intellectual glory, he had now, at the age of fifty-two, proved himself almost inadvertently a most capable and courageous military commander. He had brought low one of the sultans of the Deccan; on that occasion he had shown himself able to inspire loyalty and a new sense of purpose in a force of dispirited soldiers. Now that Akbar himself had summoned Abu’l Fazl to court, there would be no dereliction in his duty to his friend and Padshah. His critics would be forever silenced, all those who had doubted his sincerity and his commitment. So when news reached him outside Ujjain that there were men waiting to ambush him en route to Agra, Abu’l Fazl was dismissive. ‘I cannot flee from this unwashed thief,’ scoffed the shaikh, when his long-time servant Gadai Khan Afghan suggested that Abu’l Fazl seek the help of Rai Rayan and Raja Suraj Singh and their 3,000 horses in nearby Antri. ‘My gracious sovereign has raised me from the rank of a student to the lofty position of an amir, a wazir, and a general,’ he is said to have added. ‘On this day if I act contrary to His Majesty’s opinion of me, by what name shall I be called among men…?’

Undaunted by news of what might lie in store for him, Abu’l Fazl continued on his path. Some distance outside Narwar, he was ambushed by Bir Singh Deo and a party ‘of bestial, savage Bundelas’, 500 horsemen in armour. Abu’l Fazl had pitched his tents and was in the white garments and gold-embroidered robes of Friday when his camp was attacked. Abu’l Fazl fought bravely, we are told. Most of his small band of companions fell trying to protect their master. Abu’l Fazl was speared in the chest as he urged his horse forward and was thrown off his mount. The Ethiopian Jabbar Khassa-khail dragged the wounded shaikh to safety. Abu’l Fazl was still alive when Bir Singh Deo rode up. The Orchha prince dismounted and, taking Abu’l Fazl’s head onto his lap, told him gently that ‘Jahangir’ had sent for him. The mortally wounded shaikh still had enough spirit in him to abuse the ‘unwashed thief ’ while Jabbar Khassa-khail, enraged, attacked the Rajput soldiers. But the Ethiopian was soon overwhelmed, and Abu’l